



***Promoting Organic Farming Practices for Health and Sustainability in  
Hajiganj, Chandpur***

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# ***Promoting Organic Farming Practices for Health and Sustainability in Hajiganj, Chandpur***

## **Situational Analysis**

In rural agricultural regions like Hajiganj upazila of Chandpur, chemical-intensive farming practices have become the norm due to pressure for high yields, easy availability of synthetic inputs, and lack of awareness about sustainable alternatives. Farmers frequently use pesticides, chemical fertilizers, and growth hormones, which can contaminate soil and groundwater, reduce long-term soil fertility, and pose health risks to both farmers and consumers.

A study by the Bangladesh Agricultural Research Council (BARC, 2020) found that over 60% of vegetables and fruits in rural markets contained unsafe pesticide residues. Continuous exposure to these chemicals has been linked to skin diseases, reproductive health problems, and even cancer, according to reports from ICDDR,B. Furthermore, agrochemical runoff contributes to pollution of nearby rivers and ponds, affecting aquatic life and drinking water sources.

Organic agriculture which emphasizes natural composting, crop rotation, biological pest control, and avoidance of synthetic chemicals presents a healthy, environmentally sustainable alternative. However, awareness and capacity to adopt these practices in Hajiganj are still very limited. Many farmers lack the technical training, government support, or market access to switch to organic farming, despite long-term benefits.

## **Stakeholder**

In the context of promoting organic agriculture in Hajiganj, Chandpur, several key stakeholders hold significant influence over the campaign's success. Foremost among these are smallholder farmers, who are the primary implementers of agricultural practices in the area. They represent the most directly affected group in this transition and are essential to engage with empathy and practical solutions. However, these farmers often rely on conventional chemical inputs due to a lack of technical knowledge about organic alternatives, limited access to training, and economic concerns regarding yield and profitability.

Supporting these farmers are government agencies like the Department of Agricultural Extension (DAE), which plays a critical role in facilitating farmer education, providing expert guidance, and aligning local practices with national sustainable agriculture goals. The Union Parishad leaders, including chairpersons and members, act as influential local governance figures who can mobilize community participation, provide institutional support, and connect the campaign to policy-level decision-making. Additionally, NGOs such as BRAC, Shushilan, and Uddipan are active in rural development and can offer resources, training programs, and facilitation support. These organizations have strong community links and can help introduce organic practices in a scalable and structured manner.

Meanwhile, agro-input sellers, particularly those dealing in chemical fertilizers and pesticides, represent a group whose interests may be challenged by the campaign. Their resistance could stem from economic dependency on the sale of chemical products, and thus they require careful engagement—possibly through introducing them to organic alternatives to diversify their product range. Lastly, schoolteachers, religious leaders (imams), and local media such as community radio and local newspapers are critical in shaping public opinion. These figures can reinforce the campaign’s messages by leveraging their authority and trust within the community.

### Audience Analysis

| Audience Segment    | Demographics                                   | Knowledge & Attitudes                                                  | Current Practices                            | Barriers                                                 | Motivators                                                                           |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Smallholder Farmers | Men and women, 18-55, limited formal education | Low awareness of organic methods; Skeptical due to fear of income loss | Heavy use of chemical fertilizers/pesticides | Lack of training, Risk of yield loss, Market uncertainty | Health improvement, Reduced costs, Long-term soil fertility, and Sustainable farming |

|                           |                                                   |                                                                                   |                                                               |                                                                     |                                                                                          |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Local Consumers</b>    | men (mainly farmers),<br>45, moderate education   | limited awareness about food safety; concerned about family and children's health | purchase from local markets without label awareness           | limited availability of organic products, low trust in authenticity | demand for safe, chemical-free vegetables for family health                              |
| <b>Youth and Students</b> | ages 14–25, mostly students, both male and female | curious and more environmentally conscious; open to trying new practices          | volunteer help in family farms or attend agricultural schools | use social platforms for participation, lack structured guidance    | education, school projects, community involvement, create employment in sustainable agri |
| <b>Community Leaders</b>  | farmers, teachers, health workers                 | supportive of development, education, and local farming                           | involved in awareness programs occasionally                   | lack technical knowledge about organic culture                      | community care, moral responsibility, and leadership promotion                           |

## SWOT Analysis

### Strengths

**High Community Dependence on Agriculture:** The majority of the population in Hajiganj relies on agriculture for their livelihood, which makes the community more receptive to initiatives that aim to improve farming systems. Their vested interest in land productivity and crop health creates a natural alignment with organic practices.

**Rising Health Awareness:** There is a growing concern among both farmers and consumers about the harmful effects of chemical pesticides and fertilizers. Many community members have reported health issues linked to chemical exposure, which can be a strong motivator for change.

**Support from Local Institutions:** Government departments like the Department of Agricultural Extension (DAE), along with NGOs active in the region, are supportive of environmentally sustainable farming. Their involvement enhances the campaign's credibility and increases access to resources, training, and networks.

**Traditional Knowledge Base:** Many older farmers have prior experience with organic or low-input farming methods from before the Green Revolution. This generational knowledge can be tapped into and revitalized, making the transition smoother.

**Natural Fertility of Land:** The region's soil and climate conditions are naturally suitable for a range of organic crops. This gives Hajiganj an ecological advantage for organic cultivation without heavy reliance on synthetic inputs.

## **Weaknesses**

**Lack of Technical Knowledge:** Most farmers are not familiar with organic farming techniques such as composting, crop rotation, or biological pest control. This lack of knowledge poses a significant barrier to immediate adoption.

**Fear of Low Yield and Income Loss:** There is a widespread perception among farmers that organic farming will reduce crop yields and compromise their financial stability. This fear makes them resistant to changing their current practices.

**Limited Access to Organic Inputs:** Materials such as compost, neem-based pesticides, and biofertilizers are either unavailable or too costly in rural markets, making it difficult for farmers to access the necessary tools for organic farming.

**Market Uncertainty:** There is no established local certification or reliable market for organic products. Farmers are unsure if there will be a price premium or steady demand, which discourages them from taking the risk to transition.

**Low Literacy and Media Access:** Some members of the primary audience have limited access to formal education and digital media, which can hinder the effectiveness of certain communication strategies like online training or social media campaigns.

## **Opportunities**

**Growing Consumer Demand for Safe Food:** Urban and semi-urban consumers are increasingly seeking pesticide-free, safe food. This trend can be leveraged to create a niche market for organic produce from Hajiganj.

**Supportive Policy Environment:** Bangladesh's national agricultural policy promotes sustainable and eco-friendly farming practices. This policy framework can be used to advocate for more local support, subsidies, and training for organic farming.

**School and Youth Engagement:** Youth and students are often more receptive to environmental education. Schools and madrasa-based eco-clubs can be used as platforms to spread awareness and develop youth-led organic initiatives.

**Potential for Partnerships:** NGOs, local agri-businesses, and even universities or agricultural research centers may be interested in collaborating on pilot programs, training, or certification schemes.

**Climate Resilience:** Organic farming practices improve soil health and water retention, which can help farmers adapt to the effects of climate change, such as irregular rainfall or soil degradation—a growing concern in rural areas.

## **Threats**

**Resistance from Agro-chemical Businesses:** Local pesticide and fertilizer dealers may oppose the campaign as it threatens their business. They could spread misinformation about organic farming or actively discourage farmers from adopting new practices.

**Initial Transition Costs:** While organic farming may be cheaper in the long run, the upfront investment in training, new inputs, or certifications may be too high for some farmers without financial support.

**Lack of Certification and Standards:** Without a clear and affordable organic certification system in place, farmers may struggle to prove the authenticity of their produce and miss out on premium pricing opportunities.

**Weather-Related Challenges:** Climate variability, such as heavy rainfall or drought, can severely affect crop performance. Organic farming, which is less reliant on chemical “quick fixes,” may be more vulnerable in the short term if proper training is not provided.

**Social Resistance to Change:** Traditional mindsets, misinformation, or community rumors can hinder the acceptance of new ideas, especially if they challenge long-standing farming habits passed down through generations.

## **Review of Previous or Existing Campaigns on Organic Farming in Bangladesh**

### **1. BRAC's Promoting Organic Agriculture Program**

BRAC, one of Bangladesh's largest NGOs, has been active in promoting organic farming for over a decade. Their "Promoting Organic Agriculture" program focuses on increasing farmer knowledge of organic practices, providing organic inputs, and creating market access for organic products. The campaign has involved training programs, farmer-to-farmer knowledge sharing, and the establishment of organic farming demonstration plots.

#### **Strengths:**

BRAC successfully utilized farmer training, which created a ripple effect as trained farmers shared their knowledge with neighbors.

The initiative built local capacity by integrating organic farming into community development projects.

BRAC's strong connection to farmers and local networks helped them overcome the challenge of market access by facilitating direct sales and certification through international organic standards.

#### **Weaknesses:**

The transition to organic farming often involves a financial investment that many farmers in rural Bangladesh cannot afford without subsidies or loans.

Despite training, some farmers were reluctant to fully commit to organic practices due to initial low yields.

### **2. Uddipan's Sustainable Agriculture and Organic Farming Program**

Uddipan is another NGO focused on rural development, particularly in areas like Chandpur. Their "Sustainable Agriculture and Organic Farming" program promotes environmental conservation through organic farming methods. Uddipan has run campaigns aimed at educating smallholder farmers about the dangers of chemical pesticide use and the benefits of organic practices. They emphasize soil health, crop diversity, and reduced dependence on external inputs.

**Strengths:**

Uddipan's campaign effectively combined awareness-raising activities with direct support for farmers, such as access to organic seeds and materials.

They partnered with local stakeholders, including schools and community centers, to broaden the campaign's reach and make it more accessible.

**Weaknesses:**

Like many other organic farming campaigns, Uddipan faced challenges in ensuring the long-term adoption of organic practices due to market-related concerns (e.g., price premiums for organic produce were not always assured).

The campaign struggled with convincing more affluent farmers, who were used to high-yield chemical-intensive farming methods, to make the switch to organic farming.

**3. Ministry of Agriculture's National Organic Farming Campaign**

The Bangladesh Ministry of Agriculture has periodically launched national-level campaigns to promote organic farming as part of broader agricultural reforms. These campaigns typically focus on introducing organic farming techniques to a larger audience, providing support for certification, and creating a more formal infrastructure for organic agriculture.

**Strengths:**

The Ministry's campaigns benefit from government backing, giving them credibility and political support.

National-level efforts can potentially reach a wide audience and influence policy changes in favor of organic agriculture.

**Weaknesses:**

These campaigns often face implementation gaps at the grassroots level, where local challenges such as lack of awareness, inadequate infrastructure, and resistance to change are prominent.

The Ministry's campaigns may not always engage with the private sector or provide enough incentives for farmers to adopt organic practices consistently.



#### **4. The Go Green Bangladesh Initiative by Grameenphone**

This campaign, while not directly related to agriculture, promotes sustainable living and environmental conservation. It targets urban populations but has helped raise awareness about sustainability, including in rural areas where farming practices directly impact the environment.

##### **Strengths:**

The campaign's success in raising environmental awareness in urban centers could be leveraged for similar efforts in rural areas, highlighting the broader environmental benefits of organic farming.

As a mobile network operator, Grameenphone has a unique platform for reaching rural farmers through text messaging and mobile apps, potentially expanding the outreach of future agricultural campaigns.

##### **Weaknesses:**

The urban-centric nature of the campaign means that rural farmers were not the primary focus, limiting the campaign's direct impact on agricultural practices in rural areas.

The campaign's message, although effective in raising awareness, lacked specific solutions for farmers, which may have contributed to limited tangible outcomes in organic farming.

##### **Lessons Learned and Implications for the Campaign**

From these existing campaigns, several key lessons can be drawn that will inform your own advocacy campaign for organic farming in Hajiganj, Chandpur:

**Farmer Education is Key:** Continuous, hands-on training and education are vital for overcoming resistance to change. The success of BRAC and Uddipan shows that when farmers understand the benefits and learn practical methods, they are more likely to adopt organic practices.

**Market Access is Crucial:** Both BRAC and Uddipan faced challenges related to ensuring market access for organic produce. Establishing direct consumer connections and exploring certification schemes will be essential for ensuring farmers see a financial benefit from organic farming.

**Financial Support and Incentives:** To overcome the economic barriers that prevent farmers from making the switch, it is essential to integrate financial support such as subsidies, low-interest loans, or guaranteed purchase agreements for organic products. A clear, accessible pathway for farmers to enter the organic market is key.

**Collaborations with Local Networks:** Partnering with local leaders, NGOs, and community groups can help spread the message more effectively. Engaging schoolteachers, imams, and other trusted community figures could significantly boost the campaign's credibility and outreach.

**Local Context Matters:** Campaigns must be tailored to local needs and realities. What works in one part of Bangladesh may not directly apply in Hajiganj, so incorporating community feedback and adjusting messages accordingly is essential.

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### **Work Distribution**

**Ahsan Habib** wrote the Situational Analysis, Campaign Strategy & Theoretical Framework, and Budget & Resource Allocation sections. He also co-developed the Implementation Plan and contributed to editing the final document.

**Sad Bin Abbas Sanim** prepared the SWOT Analysis, Audience Analysis (table), and Cultural & Ethical Considerations. He also co-wrote the Implementation Plan and participated in final proofreading.

**Zamiul Haque** wrote the Stakeholder Analysis, Review of Previous Campaigns, and Monitoring & Evaluation Plan. He also handled all referencing and helped with final revisions.